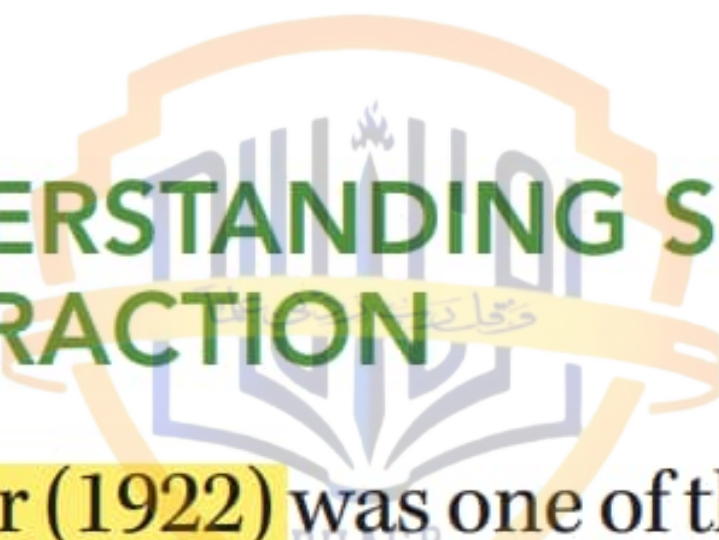
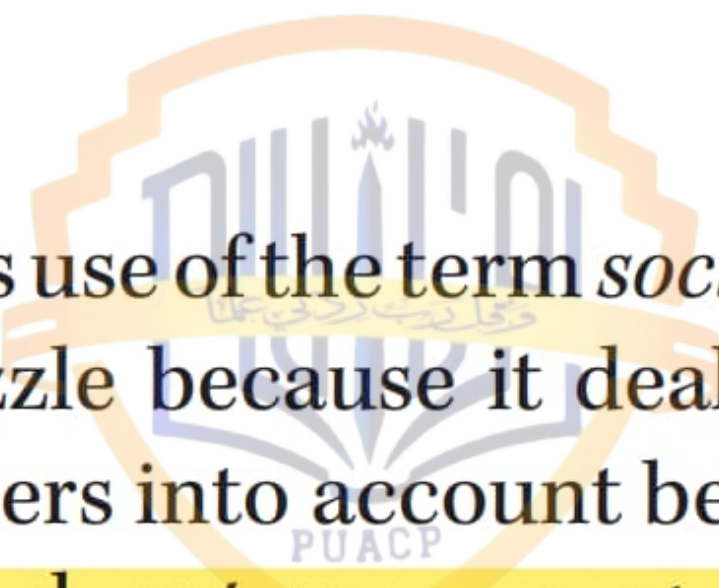


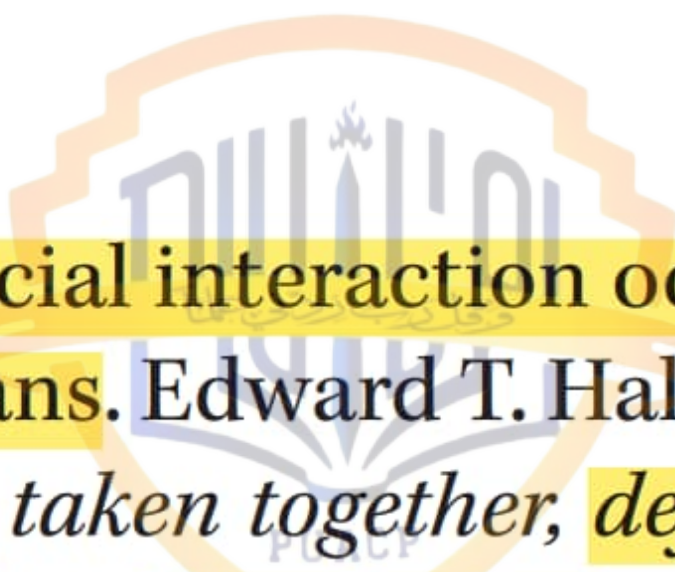


● UNDERSTANDING SOCIAL INTERACTION

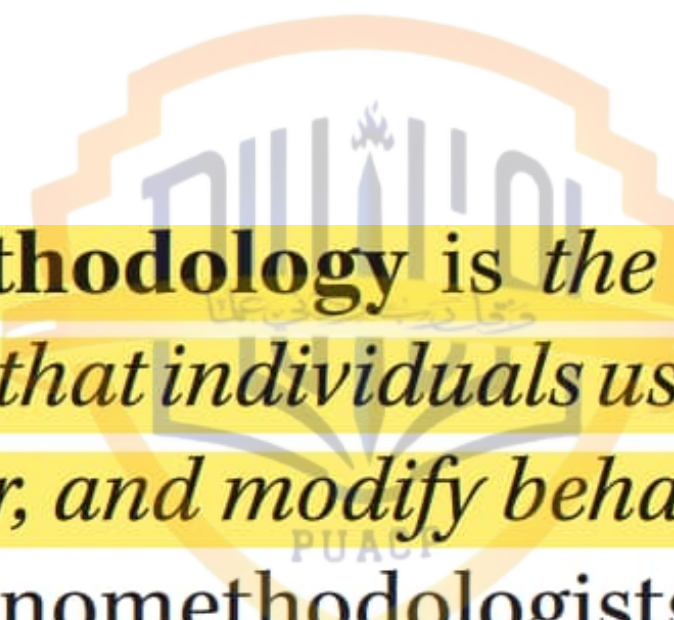
Max Weber (1922) was one of the first sociologists to stress the importance of social interaction in the study of sociology. He argued that the main goal of sociology is to explain what he called **social action**, a term he used to refer to *anything people are conscious of doing because of other people*.

The logo of the Palestinian University of Applied Sciences (PUACP) is visible in the background. It features a shield-like emblem with Arabic calligraphy and a central torch. The acronym 'PUACP' is printed below the emblem.

Weber's use of the term *social action* identifies only half of the puzzle because it deals only with one individual taking others into account before acting. **A social interaction** involves *two or more people taking one another into account*. It is the **interplay between the actions of these individuals**. In this respect, **social interaction is a central concept to understanding the nature of social life.**



Where a social interaction occurs makes a difference in what it means. Edward T. Hall (1974) identified *three elements that, taken together, define the context of a social interaction*: (1) *the physical setting or place*, (2) *the social environment*, and (3) *the activities surrounding the interaction—preceding it, happening simultaneously with it, and coming after it.*



Ethnomethodology is *the study of the sets of rules or guidelines that individuals use to initiate behavior, respond to behavior, and modify behavior in social settings.*

For ethnomethodologists, all social interactions are equally important because they provide information about a society's unwritten rules for social behavior—the shared knowledge that is basic to social life.

People create impressions, and others respond with their own impressions. Erving Goffman (1959, 1963, 1971) concluded that a central feature of human interaction is impression formation—the attempt to present oneself to others in a particular way. Goffman believed that much human interaction can be studied and analyzed on the basis of principles derived from the theater. This approach, known as **dramaturgy**, states that *to create an impression, people play roles, and their performance is judged by others who are alert to any slips that might reveal the actor's true character.* For example, a job applicant at an interview tries to appear composed, self-confident, and capable of handling the position's responsibilities. The interviewer is watching for

The logo of the University of Peshawar is a circular emblem with an orange border. Inside, there is a stylized blue and white design featuring a central torch or flame-like element. The text 'PUACP' is written in blue across the middle of the emblem.

● TYPES OF SOCIAL INTERACTION

When two individuals are in each other's presence, they inevitably affect each other. They might do so intentionally, as when one person asks the other for change for a dollar, or they might do so unintentionally, as when two people drift toward opposite sides of the elevator

Nonverbal Behavior

Many researchers have focused our attention on how we communicate with one another by using body movements. This study of body movements, known as *kinesics*, attempts to examine how such things as “slight head nods, yawns, postural shifts, and other nonverbal cues, whether spontaneous or deliberate, affect communication” (Samovar, Porter, and Jain, 1981).

Our culture has taught us a variety of appropriate communication procedures. When they are followed

Eye contact

Waving hand

Smirk

Bow

Exchange

*When people do something for each other with the express purpose of receiving a reward or return, they are involved in an **exchange interaction**.*

Most employer–employee relationships are exchange relationships. The employee does the job and is rewarded with a salary. The reward in an exchange interaction, however, need not always be material; it can also be based on emotions such as gratitude.

Cooperation

A **cooperative interaction** occurs *when people act together to promote common interests or achieve shared goals.*

The members of a basketball team pass to one another, block off opponents for one another, rebound, and assist one another to achieve a common goal—winning the game. Likewise, family members cooperate to promote their interests as a family—the husband and wife both

Conflict

In a cooperative interaction, people join forces to achieve a common goal. By contrast, people in conflict struggle with one another for some commonly prized object or value. In most conflict relationships, only one person can gain at someone else's expense. Conflicts arise when people or groups have incompatible values or when the rewards or resources available to a society or its members are limited. Thus, conflict usually involves an

Competition

The fifth type of social interaction, **competition**, is *a form of conflict in which individuals or groups confine their conflict within agreed-upon rules.*

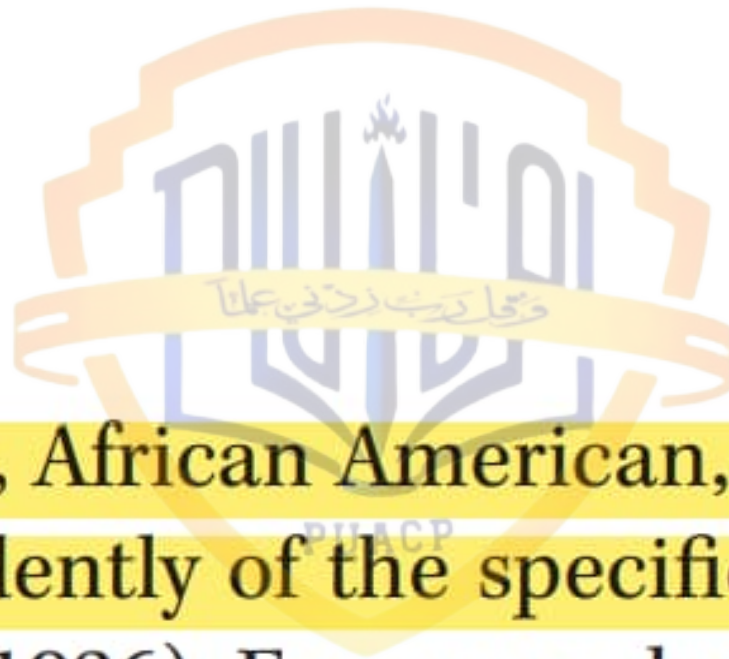
Competition is a common form of interaction in the modern world—not only on the sports field but in the marketplace, the education system, and the political system. American presidential elections, for example, are based on competition. Candidates for each party

● ELEMENTS OF SOCIAL INTERACTION

People do not interact with one another as anonymous beings. They come together in the context of specific environments and with specific purposes. Their interactions involve behaviors associated with defined statuses and particular roles. These statuses and roles help pattern our social interactions and provide predictability.

Statues

Statues are *socially defined positions that people occupy*. Common statues can pertain to religion, education, ethnicity, and occupation, for example, Protestant, college



graduate, African American, and teacher. Statuses exist independently of the specific people who occupy them (Linton, 1936). For example, our society recognizes the status of politician.



FIGURE 5–1 Status and Master Status

Generally, each individual occupies many statuses at one time. The statuses of a female executive at major television network include author, wife, mother, pianist, and so on. Other statuses could be added to this list. However, one status—vice-president for programming—is most important in patterning this woman's life. Sociologists call such a status **a master status**.

Some statuses, called **ascribed statuses**, are *conferred upon us by virtue of birth or other significant factors not controlled by our own actions or decisions; people occupy them regardless of their intentions*. Certain family positions, such as that of daughter or son, are typical ascribed statuses, as are one's gender and ethnic or racial identity. Other statuses, called **achieved statuses**, are *acquired as a result of the individual's actions*—student, professor, garage mechanic, race car driver, artist, prisoner, bus driver, husband, wife, mother, or father.

Roles

Statuses alone are static—nothing more than social categories into which people are put. Roles bring statuses to life, making them dynamic. As Robert Linton (1936) observed, you occupy a status, but you play a role. **Roles** are *the culturally defined rules for proper behavior that are associated with every status*.

Roles may be thought of as collections of rights and obligations. For example, to be a race car driver, you



A status can include a number of roles, and each role will be appropriate to a specific social context. For example, as the child of a military officer, Kay Redfield



Role Sets

All the roles attached to a single status are known collectively as a **role set**. However, not every role in a particular role set is enacted all the time. An individual's role

behaviors depend on the statuses of the other people with whom he or she is interacting. For example, as a college student, you behave one way toward other students and another way toward professors. Similarly, professors behave one way toward other professors, another way toward students, and yet a third way toward deans. So the role behavior we expect in any given situation depends on the pairs of statuses that the interacting individuals occupy. This means that role behavior really is defined by the rights and obligations that are assigned to statuses

Role Strain

Even though most people try to enact their roles as they are expected to, they sometimes find it difficult.

*When a single role has conflicting demands attached to it, individuals who play that role experience **role strain*** (Goode, 1960). For example, the captain of a freighter is expected to be sure the ship sails only when it is in safe condition, but the captain also is expected to meet the company's delivery schedule because a day's delay could cost the company thousands of dollars. These two expectations can exert competing pulls on the captain,

Role Conflict

*An individual who is occupying more than one status at a time and who is unable to enact the role of one status without violating that of another status is encountering **role conflict**.* Not long ago, pregnancy was considered women's work. An expectant father was expected to get his wife to the hospital on time and to pace the waiting room, anxiously awaiting the nurse's report on the sex of the baby and its health. Today, men are encouraged and even expected to participate fully in the pregnancy and the birth of the child. A role conflict arises, however, in that although the

Role Playing

The roles we play can have a profound influence on both our attitudes and our behavior. Playing a new social role often feels awkward at first, and we might feel we are just acting—pretending to be something that we are not. However, many sociologists feel that the roles a person plays are the person's only true self. Peter Berger's (1963) explanation of role playing goes further: The roles we play can transform not only our actions but also ourselves.



The Social Construction of Reality

What holds society together? This is a basic question for sociologists, one that, as we have seen, has long guided sociological thinking. Sociologists note that society cannot hold together without something that is shared—a shared social reality.

Some sociological theorists have argued convincingly that there is little actual reality beyond that produced by the process of social interaction itself. This is the principle of the *social construction of reality*, the idea that our perception of what is real is determined by the subjective meaning that we attribute to an experience, a principle central to symbolic interaction theory (Berger and Luckmann 1967; Blumer 1969). Hence, there is no objective “reality” in itself. Things do not have their own intrinsic meaning. We subjectively impose meaning on things.

Ethnomethodology

Our interactions are guided by rules that we follow. Sometimes these rules are non-obvious and subtle. These rules are the *norms* of social interaction. Again, what holds society together? Society cannot hold together without norms, but what rules do we follow? How do we know what these rules or norms are? An approach in sociology called *ethnomethodology* is a clever technique for finding out.

Ethnomethodology (Garfinkel 1967), after *ethno* for “people” and *methodology* for “mode of study,” is a clever technique for studying human interaction by deliberately disrupting social norms and observing how individuals attempt to restore normalcy. The idea



is that to study such norms, one must first break them, because the subsequent behavior of the people involved will reveal just what the norms were in the first place.

- ***What is society?***

Society is a system of social interaction that includes both culture and *social organization*. Society includes *social institutions*, or established organized social behavior, and exists for a recognized purpose; *social structure* is the patterned relationships within a society.

- ***What holds society together?***

According to theorist Emile Durkheim, society with all its complex social organization and culture, is held together, depending on overall type, by *mechanical solidarity* (based on individual similarity) and *organic solidarity* (based on a *division of labor* among dissimilar individuals).

- ***What are the types of societies?***

Societies across the globe vary in type, as determined mainly by the complexity of their social structures, their division of labor, and their technologies. From least to most complex, they are *foraging*, *pastoral*, *horticultural*, *agricultural* (these four constitute *preindustrial* societies), *industrial*, and *postindustrial* societies.

- ***What are the forms of social interaction in society?***

All forms of social interaction in society are shaped by the structure of its social institutions. A *group* is a collection of individuals who interact and communicate with each other, share goals and norms, and have a subjective awareness of themselves as a distinct social unit. *Status* is a hierarchical position in a structure; a *role* is the expected behavior associated with a particular status. A *role* is the behavior others expect from a person associated with a particular status. Patterns of social interaction

influence nonverbal interaction as well as patterns of attraction and affiliation.

What theories are there about social interaction?

Social interaction takes place in society within the context of social structure and social institutions. Social interaction is analyzed in several ways, including the *social construction of reality* (we impose meaning and reality on our interactions with others); *ethnomethodology* (deliberate interruption of interaction to observe how a return to “normal” interaction is accomplished); *impression management* (a person “gives off” a particular impression to “con” the other and achieve certain goals, as in *cyberspace interaction*); and *social exchange* and *game theory* (one engages in gamelike reward and punishment interactions to achieve